

PHASE 1 SLATE (2008–2012): 8 FILMS

Status:  all 8 slots filled. Each film still needs its full Film Dossier before it's locked.

#	Title	Release date	Owner	Dossier
1	Iron Man	Friday, May 2, 2008	Marc-Anthony Bullock	 complete
2	The Incredible Hulk	Friday, June 13, 2008	Amond Baker	 pending
3	Thor	Friday, May 1, 2009	Esther Smilley	 pending
4	Ant-Man (with the Wasp; final title set in the dossier)	Friday, November 6, 2009	Tyler Chapman (Elxa Bullock co-lead)	 pending
5	Iron Man 2	Friday, May 7, 2010	Marc-Anthony Bullock	 pending
6	Captain America	Friday, July 22, 2011	Tyrese Avery	 pending
7	X-Men	Friday, November 4, 2011	The X-Men ensemble (real actors, showrunner's picks) · Grace Bullock as the Scarlet Witch	 pending
8	The Avengers	Friday, May 4, 2012	The ensemble (Marc-Anthony Bullock top-billed)	 pending

FILM #1: IRON MAN (why it kicks everything off)

- **Character:** Tony Stark / Iron Man. First appearance: *Tales of Suspense* #39 (March 1963), Stan Lee, Larry Lieber, Don Heck and Jack Kirby.
- **Why Iron Man goes first, even though we own everyone:**
- **Thanos debuted in an Iron Man comic.** Jim Starlin introduced him in *Iron Man* #55 (Feb. 1973), so starting the Infinity Saga with Iron Man is comic-accurate at the very root.
- **He's the most grounded way in.** Iron Man runs on technology instead of magic, mutation or the cosmos, so a 2008 audience can believe it. Every later film makes the world a little bigger from there.

- **Tony pays for the Avengers.** On 616, Stark money builds the team and Stark's mansion becomes its home. The man who funds the Avengers should be the first one we meet.
- **S.H.I.E.L.D. fits naturally.** A defense contractor is exactly who Nick Fury would show up to see.
- **The underdog story matches the studio's.** It's a B-list hero from a studio that's never made a movie, starring an actor Hollywood wrote off. Tony, Marc-Anthony and Marvel all have something to prove.
- **Release date: Friday, May 2, 2008.** It's the first weekend of the summer season, a week ahead of *Speed Racer* (May 9) and three weeks ahead of *Indiana Jones and the Kingdom of the Crystal Skull* (May 22), which gives it room to hold on for several weekends.

FILM #2: THE INCREDIBLE HULK

- **Character:** Bruce Banner / the Hulk. First appearance: *The Incredible Hulk #1* (May 1962), Stan Lee & Jack Kirby.
- **Why second:** he's a **founding Avenger**, and in *Avengers #1* **the Hulk is the reason the team forms** (Loki frames him). Audiences need to meet him before that. It also pairs naturally with Iron Man: both are science origins, and Tony's workshop TV already reported the gamma accident at Desert Base. It's a grounded fugitive thriller that widens the world one step.
- **Release date: Friday, June 13, 2008.** Six weeks after *Iron Man*, so Marvel has two films in theaters in one summer. It also avoids *Hancock* (July 2) and *The Dark Knight* (July 18).

FILM #3: THOR

- **Character:** Thor Odinson. First appearance: *Journey into Mystery #83* (August 1962), Stan Lee, Larry Lieber & Jack Kirby.
- **Why third:** he's a **founding Avenger**, and **Loki, the villain who brings the Avengers together** in *Avengers #1*, comes from Thor's world. After two science films, Thor opens the door to **gods, magic and the Nine Realms**, and **the cosmos where Thanos lives**.
- **Release date: Friday, May 1, 2009.** It opens the 2009 summer season, the same slot *Iron Man* used, and comes a week ahead of *Star Trek* (May 8).

FILM #4: ANT-MAN (with the Wasp)

- **Characters:** Dr. Hank Pym / Ant-Man, first appearing in *Tales to Astonish #27* (January 1962) and in costume in #35 (September 1962), and Janet van Dyne / the Wasp, first appearing in *Tales to Astonish #44* (June 1963). Stan Lee, Larry Lieber, H.E. Huebner & Jack Kirby.
- **Why fourth:** Ant-Man and the Wasp are **two of the five founding Avengers**, and **the Wasp names the team**. One film brings in both, as the comics did, and pays off the Pym journal from *Iron Man*. It's sci-fi adventure at impossible scale, a fresh genre after armor, monster and myth.
- **Release date: Friday, November 6, 2009.** It opens the holiday corridor with four more weeks of family audiences behind it.

- **Casting:** Tyler Chapman (Hank) and Elxa Bullock (Janet) are announced together at San Diego Comic-Con on July 26, 2008. Elxa has already appeared secretly as Janet in *Iron Man*.

FILM #5: IRON MAN 2

- **Character:** Tony Stark / Iron Man, the first sequel.
- **Release date: Friday, May 7, 2010.** The first Friday in May, two years after the original. It pays off the Mandarin's rings and "Next time, baby."

FILM #6: CAPTAIN AMERICA

- **Character:** Steve Rogers / Captain America. First appearance: *Captain America Comics #1* (March 1941, cover-dated), Joe Simon & Jack Kirby. The Avengers find him in the ice in *Avengers #4* (March 1964).
- **Why sixth:**
- **Cap closes out the founding era the way the comics did.** In 616 he wasn't a founder. He joined in *Avengers #4* after the Avengers **found him frozen in the ice**. His film ends with Steve going into the ice, and *The Avengers* is where the team finds him.
- **It's the MCU's only period piece.** A WWII war epic from 1941 to 1945 gives the saga its history: **Project: Rebirth** and **Dr. Abraham Erskine, Bucky Barnes, the Red Skull, and Sgt. Nick Fury and his Howling Commandos** (616: they fought beside Cap). That's also where Samuel L. Jackson's Fury history comes from.
- **It sets up the Big Bad accurately to the comics.** The Red Skull's **Cosmic Cube** is the prize **Thanos went after first** in *Captain Marvel #27–33* (1973), before he ever went for the Gems. The Cube shows up in the Skull's hands in 1945, and Thanos will come for it.
- **Release date: Friday, July 22, 2011.** It's the heart of summer, three weeks after Independence Day, and clear of *Transformers: Dark of the Moon* (June 29). Paramount distributes both films and wouldn't put them head to head. It also comes a week after the final *Harry Potter* (July 15), once that film's opening surge has passed.

FILM #7: X-MEN

- **Characters:** the original X-Men: **Professor Charles Xavier** and his first students **Cyclops, Marvel Girl (Jean Grey), the Beast, Iceman and the Angel**. They face **Magneto** and the **Brotherhood of Evil Mutants**, including **the Scarlet Witch and Quicksilver**.
- **Comics: *The X-Men #1*** (September 1963), Stan Lee & Jack Kirby. The Brotherhood, with Wanda and Pietro, first appears in *X-Men #4* (March 1964).
- **Why seventh:**
- **It's the Avengers' twin launch.** *The X-Men #1* and *The Avengers #1* both carry a **September 1963** cover date, from the same creators in the same month. Putting X-Men right before *The Avengers* matches

how the comics started.

- **We own them, and nobody gets left out.** In our reality no other studio has ever made an X-Men film. This is the world's first look at mutants, the X-gene and the dream of Charles Xavier.
- **It brings in the Scarlet Witch the 616 way.** Wanda (Grace Bullock) and her brother Pietro debut as **reluctant members of Magneto's Brotherhood**. As of 2011 on 616, **Magneto is their father**. They leave him and reform, which sets up "**Cap's Kooky Quartet**" (*Avengers* #16) for Phase 2.
- **It makes the world bigger.** After technology, gamma, gods, size-changing science and a super-soldier, the last kind of hero is **born, not made**. Mutants give the Avengers a world they share with a feared minority, and Marvel's biggest social theme.
- **Release date: Friday, November 4, 2011.** It opens the holiday corridor again, fifteen weeks after *Captain America*. The competition is *Tower Heist* (the same day), and it comes two weeks ahead of *The Twilight Saga: Breaking Dawn – Part 1* (November 18).
- **Casting note:** under the Casting Rules, the X-Men and Magneto are played by **real actors, and the showrunner picks** where more than one real actor played a role. Quicksilver is a showrunner's pick too. **Grace Bullock (Wanda)** is announced at San Diego Comic-Con on July 24, 2010.

FILM #8: THE AVENGERS (Phase 1 finale)

- **Comics: *The Avengers* #1** (September 1963, Lee & Kirby), the founding against Loki, and ***The Avengers* #4** (March 1964), where the team finds Captain America in the ice.
- **Release date: Friday, May 4, 2012.** The first Friday in May, Marvel's summer-opening slot from *Iron Man* on. It gets **eleven weeks** of clear room before *The Dark Knight Rises* (July 20). *The Amazing Spider-Man* (July 3) doesn't exist in our reality, because Spider-Man belongs to Marvel.
- **Distributor: Walt Disney Studios Motion Pictures.** Disney bought Paramount's distribution rights after the 2009 acquisition, so this is the first MCU film released by Disney.
- **Why May 4 works:** it's four years to the weekend after *Iron Man*, and the eight-film plan comes together at the start of summer. The Phase 1 final shot is a purple hand, a golden glove, and "**To challenge them... is to court Death.**"

Phase 1 so far: the founders come first

By *Iron Man 2*, **four of the five founding Avengers** (Iron Man, Hulk, Thor, Ant-Man) plus the Wasp have been introduced. Slot #6 is **Captain America**, whom the Avengers find frozen in the ice as in 616. Slot #7 is **X-Men**, the Avengers' twin launch from September 1963, and **The Avengers** is Film #8 (2012).